

this launch. To the paranoid, this is a deal-breaker, and the most compelling reason to hang on to Windows XP for now.

BETTER USE

Windows Vista comes with a few tools to enhance your productivity at home and in the office, and the interface has been given an overhaul—we're not just talking about the visuals.

Windows Collaboration

The replacement for NetMeeting, Windows Collaboration is a peer-to-peer application that lets up to ten people start a collaborative session over the office network. Jointly work on desktops and files, make presentations, and pass notes about the boss' attitude privately—all without needing a conference room. It's capable of ad-hoc wireless networking—setting up a network even in the absence of an access point—this will require a shift to IPv6, though.



Windows Collaboration—so much more than NetMeeting

Windows Calendar

Similar to OS X's iCal, Windows Calendar builds Outlook's PIM features right into the OS—schedule your own tasks, co-ordinate with others on the network, and even synchronise with online calendar services like Google Calendar. One giant leap for personal productivity.



Windows Calendar—a productivity application which was long overdue

The Interface

It isn't just about the cool glassy effects and Flip3D—Vista's new interface polishes a lot of the kinks we had to deal with in XP. Buttons like "OK" and "Cancel" that forced you to read the entire message are now replaced with more meaningful text—like "Install" and "Don't Install"—and some 200 unnecessary message prompts have been eliminated. Every task now has a taskbar button, so there's no more hunting for prompts or file copy dialog boxes. The Search box in the new Start menu is a much more evolved version of Start > Run—you don't need to know the exact name of

the EXE anymore! Search is also integrated into all Explorer windows—you can tag files with keywords and even filter document searches by author. The result—you *never* need to remember a folder path ever again!

Verdict

The new interface also has a large number of subtleties you're bound to miss on first use, but over time will give you a richer and smoother experience. Couple that with the new productivity tools and your workday will pass in a more streamlined manner than you can imagine.

THE PERFORMANCE FACTOR

Unless all your office PCs are brand new and have at least 1 GB of RAM and a dedicated graphics card, you're in for an upgrade—if you want Aero, that is. While this would make home users frown—buying Vista and not using Aero is like stripping the paint off a new car—it's hardly a priority for business users.

You'll also have these two features to help kick up performance:

SuperFetch

SuperFetch caches commonly used files and programs in available system memory, so over time, you'll find the OS becoming more responsive. It also has some "intelligence," loading files that it anticipates will be needed soon.

ReadyBoost

If you've got a large-capacity Flash drive, you can use it as your SuperFetch cache and free up main memory. It's slower than RAM, but much faster than reading the cache from the hard disk. ReadyBoost is also optimised to minimise the number of read/write operations it makes on your USB drive, keeping in mind that Flash drives are reliable only for a limited number of read/write cycles.

Verdict

While using Vista, we did notice significant performance improvements with ReadyBoost and there's potential for more. Don't fall for the "you'll have to upgrade your hardware" line—even without Aero, the productivity is all there, and that's what matters more.

If It Ain't Broke?

When Windows 2000 launched, offices were desperate—Windows NT 4's shortcomings were too many, and Windows 98 wasn't advisable for the workplace. Today, Vista launches in a completely different environment—Windows 2000, XP, and Server 2003 are all solid platforms (yes, despite the daily security fixes), and there is no pressing need for something new. Even so, it's doubtless a better OS and the upgrade is practically inevitable. Price isn't a factor, either—except for the Ultimate Edition, it's going to cost the same as corresponding versions of XP.

If you've just been through an upgrade cycle for your office, or don't plan on one any time soon, don't let the Vista launch rush you towards it—let it come as a logical step ahead. By then, any kinks in the OS will have been addressed as well. ■

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That you'll need an upgrade for Vista is a myth—you may not get Aero, but you'll have access to every feature that boosts productivity, and that's what matters more to the professional"

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